

HAZARD 3 — MOOSE

A moose is not a large deer. A moose is a different category of animal entirely — one that the northeastern United States wilderness traveler needs to understand before heading into moose country, which begins roughly at the Maine and northern New Hampshire borders.

An adult bull moose weighs between 900 and 1,400 pounds. He stands six feet at the shoulder. He can charge at 35 miles per hour and he can do so with less warning than you will expect, especially during the autumn rut (September–October) or when a cow is protecting a calf (May–June). More people are injured by moose in North America each year than by any other large animal.

The moose's reputation as a gentle giant is earned during peaceful encounters — and most encounters are peaceful. But the moose is not gentle. It is enormous, it is powerful, and it is indifferent to your presence in a way that can turn dangerous with little transition.

What you need to know:

- Warning signs of agitation: the animal stops feeding and locks eyes on you; ears lay flat against the head; hackles raise along the hump; the animal lowers its head. Any of these means move away, immediately, without running.
- If a moose charges, do not run in a straight line. Get behind a large tree, a boulder, or any solid barrier. Moose have difficulty changing direction at full speed. A tree between you and a charging moose is a meaningful obstacle.
- Never approach a moose for a photograph. The distance that feels safe to you is not the distance that feels safe to the moose.



- A cow with a calf is among the most dangerous large-animal encounters in North American wilderness. Give them significant space and a clear escape route.
 - Full encounter protocol is in Chapter 2.
-